

WEEKLY BUSINESS SESSION – August 12, 2026

5:30 p.m. – Anne Basker Auditorium
600 N.W. Sixth Street, Grants Pass, OR 97526

Present: Ron Smith, Chair-Commissioner; Colene Martin, Vice-Chair-Commissioner; Gary Richardson, Commissioner; Nikole Guzman, Recorder

These are meeting minutes only. Only text enclosed in quotation marks reports a speaker's exact words.

Pursuant to notice through the media and in conformance with the Public Meeting Law, Ron Smith, Chair, called the meeting to order at 5:30 p.m. followed by the Pledge of Allegiance.

Items discussed were as follows:

1. CALL MEETING TO ORDER:

Pursuant to notice through the media and in conformance with the Public Meeting Law, Ron Smith, Chair, called the meeting to order at 5:30 p.m., followed by the Pledge of Allegiance.

2. DECLARE A POTENTIAL CONFLICT OF INTEREST:

Commissioners Richardson, Martin, and Smith each declared no potential conflicts of interest.

3. ADMINISTRATIVE ACTION(S) IN CONSIDERATION OF:

a. Resolution No. 2026-031; In the Matter of Referring to Josephine County Voters at the November 3, 2026, Election a Measure for Renewal of Adult Jail and Juvenile Detention Five-Year Local Option Tax

Wally Hicks, Legal Counsel, presented the proposed five-year renewal of the existing Adult Jail and Juvenile Detention local option tax. He explained that voters first approved the levy in 2017 and renewed it in 2021, and that the current levy will expire June 30, 2027. The proposed renewal would retain the existing rate of \$0.93 per \$1,000 of assessed value for another five years.

Mr. Hicks explained that the proposal would maintain the Adult Jail's current inmate capacity of 185 and allow intake of adults arrested in Josephine County. Remaining levy revenue would be available to partially fund Juvenile Detention operations and related administrative expenses. He noted that Josephine County's permanent property tax rate is \$0.585 per \$1,000 of assessed value and that the local option levy is in addition to that permanent rate.

At the proposed \$0.93 rate, the tax would equal approximately \$7.75 per month, or \$93 per year, for each \$100,000 of assessed value. For a home with the County's cited average assessed value of \$239,908, the estimated cost would be approximately \$18.59 per month, or \$223.11 per year. Mr. Hicks stated that the deadline to submit the measure to the County Clerk for the November election was Friday, August 14, 2026.

4. REQUESTS/COMMENTS FROM CITIZENS:

(Each person was given three (3) minutes to speak.)

Herman Baertreger, Josephine County, stated that he supports funding both the Adult Jail and Juvenile Justice but opposed the proposed ballot language. He compared the proposed measure with the 2017 and 2021 levies and expressed concern that the current draft no longer assured funding for 14 juvenile detention beds. He also questioned the phrase "remaining revenue, if any" and asked for clearer language identifying how taxpayer funds would be allocated.

Victor, Grants Pass, questioned the cost and utilization of the Adult Jail and Juvenile Justice facilities and urged the County to consider the District Attorney as part of the broader public-safety funding structure. He also supported continued exploration of artificial intelligence and the COCONUT government-efficiency proposal discussed at the prior Administrative Workshop.

Adriana Rhinehart, Josephine County, identified herself as a former Josephine County prosecutor and current defense attorney who primarily represents juveniles. She stated that juveniles cannot be housed with adults, emphasized the importance of early intervention and local juvenile detention capacity, and urged the Board to support the levy while strengthening the language to provide more definite funding for Juvenile Justice.

T.J. Tice, Josephine County, described a July vehicle crash that caused substantial damage to his business property and expressed frustration with the criminal case that followed. He stated that the experience reinforced his support for adequate law-enforcement, prosecution, and jail funding.

Winnie, Grants Pass, expressed concern with the proposed ballot language and the tax burden on residents. She urged the Board to carefully consider the concerns raised regarding the wording before referring the measure to voters.

BOARD MAY REVIEW PUBLIC COMMENTS/QUESTIONS:

Commissioner Richardson made a motion to approve Resolution No. 2026-031; In the Matter of Referring to Josephine County Voters at the November 3, 2026, Election a Measure for Renewal of Adult Jail and Juvenile Detention Five-Year Local Option Tax. Commissioner Martin seconded the motion.

During discussion on the pending motion, Commissioner Martin proposed a friendly amendment to remove the words "if any" from the Measure Funding paragraph so the sentence would begin, "Remaining revenue from this measure would partially fund juvenile detention operations..." Commissioner Smith seconded the amendment, and the amendment was incorporated into the pending motion.

Mr. Hicks advised that removing the words "if any" would not materially change the practical application of the measure because the remaining language provides that Juvenile Detention operations could continue at the current service level subject to the availability of other funds, and the annual budget process would determine the amount of remaining levy revenue available in each year. The Board also discussed language stating that the Juvenile Detention Center can currently lodge up to 14 youth and reiterated the importance of maintaining the service.

Upon roll call on the motion as amended: Commissioner Richardson - Yes; Commissioner Martin - Yes; Commissioner Smith - Yes. Motion carried 3-0.

5. APPROVAL OF CONSENT CALENDAR:

a. Minutes (Draft minutes are available for viewing in the Board's Office)

Airport Advisory Board - June 2, 2026

General Discussion - August 3, 2026

Admin Workshop - August 4, 2026

Weekly Business Session - August 5, 2026

Legal Counsel Update - August 6, 2026

Commissioner Richardson made a motion to approve the Consent Calendar. Commissioner Martin seconded the motion. Upon roll call: Commissioner Richardson - Yes; Commissioner Martin - Yes; Commissioner Smith - Yes. Motion carried 3-0.

6. OTHER: (ORS 192.640(1))

No additional matters were introduced.

7. ANNOUNCEMENTS: MATTERS FROM COMMISSIONERS:

Commissioner Richardson had no announcements. Commissioner Martin stated that she hoped Mr. Baertreger would reconsider supporting the measure. Chair Smith wished his wife, Dede, a happy birthday on August 14.

Weekly Business Session adjourned at 6:03 p.m.



Nikole Guzman, Recorder